



>>Sunil Pai, UI Architect, Myntra

Tell us a bit about the CSS Library you created.

Beam (<https://github.com/threepointone/beam>) is the result of trying to do animations based on exponential smoothing algorithms. This funny little algorithm has its roots in 5th century BC greek philosophy (search for “zeno's paradoxes”) and is widely used in the 3d world, games, and motion graphics. I was trying to mimic a couple of these animations I'd seen elsewhere on the web, but with regular html elements; this led to writing an animation engine, a css serializer, helpers for css transforms, and finally Beam itself, which pulls it all together. Have a look at the funny little demo at <http://threepointone.github.io/beam>. Beam's useful for bringing physicsy animations to UI elements, which means your drag and drops looks better, and live dynamic animations become very achievable. I've used beam to implement inertial scrolling, accelerators, buttons, and even a graph smoothing algorithm.

Why JavaScript?

Hell, why not javascript? Javascript is the South Indian English dialect of the technology world; all colloquial, quirky, illogical, and the pronunciation is highly suspect. But it gets the job done, and then some! It's also good at borrowing ideas from other languages, and a good fit for multiple environments. The front end of the internet runs on it, so 'reloading' becomes your compile button. That's crazy good! I like having functions as regular objects, the dynamic/loose nature of the type system, being able

to mess with code during runtime, and the crazy, crazy community that's coming up with a 100 new ideas a day. This shit does not get old, I promise you.

Why do you hate Adobe Flash so much?

Lies! I don't hate Adobe Flash, I just didn't warm up to it. Look, when we're learning front end development, we spend endless hours reading other peoples source code - HTML, CSS and Javascript. right-click and view-source and/or inspect element becomes second nature. The colleges in India don't really teach any of that, and the browser environment itself is super hostile and quirky. I hate that margin: 0 auto; is the accepted method to center an element with CSS. This is the 21st century, ffs. And who decided that “draggable” is a css property? But I digress. Anyway, so Adobe Flash. This technology breaks the learning flow by becoming a black box. It might be a gorgeous animation, a complex application... whatever. If you're in my browser, and I can't see what you're made of, then I'm an angry man. So I've always made it a point in my career to be the guy who responds to “we can't do that in javascript” with “lemme give it a go.” Worked out well for me as a career move, and my laptop fans thank me everyday.

Why do all shopping sites look the same?

Do they, really? I think it comes from the people who get the most ‘say’, or ‘final

cut’ when it comes to the site's look and feel. So when Sunit Singh's in charge at Cleartrip, it's a given that the site will look and feel ‘designed’ and well thought out. And if it's the IRCTC, then you know that you'll want to pull out your own eyes after 20 minutes of whacking your keyboard. I like Flipkart's redesign, and Amazon's responsive layout is really neat. Myntra's always had feedback from people saying they love the typography and the ‘style’ that runs through the site; all credit to the designers in the office for that. Without giving away any secrets, I can promise big stuff happening on Myntra in the UI space, so keep an eye on the site for details. Also, we're hiring! I'm looking for the most mental folk to come join me at and create crazy beautiful web stuff.

Any advice for budding developers?

- Practice, practice, practice. The naivety of the engineering community is to believe that 4 years of ‘professional’ education are sufficient for a lifetime. The truth is you're going to have to constantly keep studying. Which is fine, really, because programming is easily the most interesting domain in the history of the world. Where else does one get to work on the science of structured thought?

Sunil Pai works as a UI Architect at Myntra. He's previously worked at Yahoo, Idiom, Visa, Pramati, and his uncle's garage. Beyond work, he writes open source for fun, and plays a blue Les Paul. He tweets at @threepointone.>

*coding matters



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Code is essential

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